



Job Description

Research Assistant

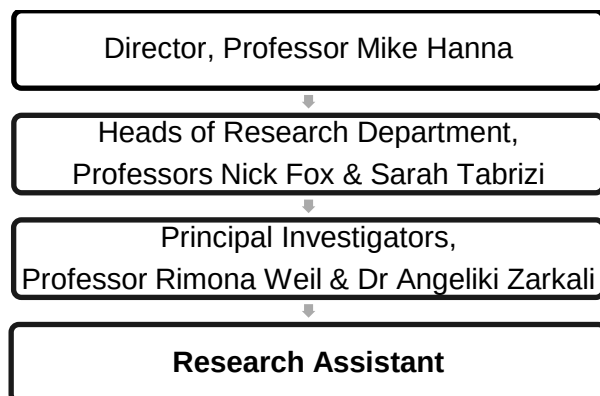
UCL Department: UCL Queen Square Institute of Neurology

Research Department: Neurodegenerative Disease

Grade: 6B

Location: Russell Square House/On-site first

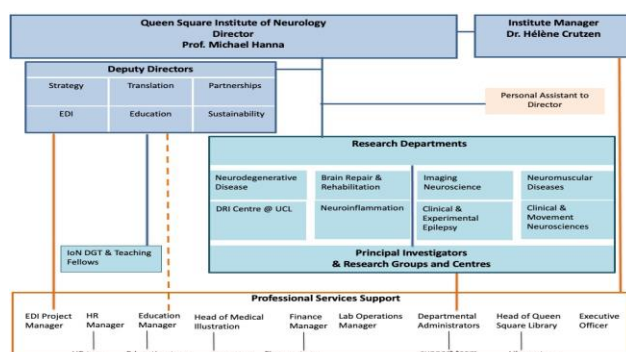
Reports to:



Line manager: Dr Angeliki Zarkali

Context

The [UCL Queen Square Institute of Neurology](#) (ION) in Queen Square was established in 1950, merged with UCL in 1997, and is a key component of the Faculty of Brain Sciences (FBS) at UCL. The Institute has [eight academic research Departments](#), which encompass clinical and basic research within each theme. In parallel, there are currently six Divisions representing clinical professional affiliations.



Our mission is to translate neuroscience discovery research into treatments for patients with neurological diseases:

- **a leading translational neuroscience centre in the world translating discovery into experimental studies in patients to deliver new diagnostics and new therapies;**
- **an excellent student destination for educational programmes embedded in translational neuroscience research;**
- **overcome fragmentation as a centre for connecting industry, commercial partners, academics, and patients to accelerate translate research, internationally.**

In addition, a number of important [research centres](#) are based at the ION, affiliated with one of our academic research departments.

The UCL Queen Square Institute of Neurology has a significant teaching and training portfolio, with over 500 graduate students at Queen Square. The Institute employs just under 750 staff, and hosts just under 300 honorary & visiting staff, spread over a complex and large estate comprising of over 15 buildings. Our annual turnover is £95 million.

The Institute is closely associated in its work with the National Hospital for Neurology & Neurosurgery (NHNN), University College London Hospitals' NHS Foundation Trust, and in combination they form a national and international centre at Queen Square for teaching, training and research in neurology and allied clinical and basic neurosciences. The Institute also has [active collaborative research programmes with other centres of excellence](#) and works in close partnership with them.

Research Excellence

A large proportion of the Institute's funding is obtained from the Higher Education Funding Council for England. IoN was a major part of REF2021 Uo4 which showed that UCL is number one in the UK for research power in psychology, psychiatry and neuroscience.

The Institute currently holds 689 active research projects, totalling £315 million, for research from the principal medical charities concerned with neurological diseases, and from government agencies such as the Medical Research Council, and we also receive significant philanthropic support.

UCL Neuroscience is currently rated second in the world by ISI Essential Science Indicators. In the calendar year 2022, Institute staff published 1959 papers; 61 were published in the top 50 of all scientific journals (ranked by ESI impact factors), including Nature, Science, Lancet, BMJ and JAMA. [RAND report](#) shows that UCL has the highest share of highly cited publications in Neurology in England.

There are 143 Principal Investigators at IoN, including: 106 professors/professorial research associates and 26 emeritus professors; 13 Fellows of the Royal Society; 35 Fellows of the Academy of Medical Sciences; 1 Nobel Prize winner.

The Institute hosts the [UK DRI Centre at UCL](#), led by Professor Karen Duff, as one of its 8 research departments.

ION-DRI: A world-class centre of excellence in neuroscience

We are building a world-class environment to fight neurological disorders through the [IoN-DRI programme](#). A new landmark facility at 256 Grays Inn Road will support our existing facilities at Queen Square to create one of the leading translational neuroscience centres in the world. The facility on Grays Inn Road will house all of IoN's wet laboratories, while the Institute's existing space in Queen Square House will be the centre for research activities with a clinical focus. Approximately half of IoN's research scientists and staff – over 500 – will be housed in the new facility. The new building is due to open in summer 2024.

Teaching excellence

The QS ION has a significant [teaching and training portfolio](#), with over 500 graduate students (including over 250 PhD students) at Queen Square, and taught MSc/MRes courses in: Advanced Neuroimaging, Brain and Mind Sciences, Clinical Neuroscience, Neuromuscular Disease, Stroke, Clinical Neurology, Dementia: Causes, Treatments and Research (Neuroscience), Translational Neuroscience and Neurosurgery.

Excellent graduate students of the highest quality are recruited to both ION and UCL-wide MPhil/ PhD programmes, which are supported through Research Council, charity and industry funded studentships, and

the Wolfson/Eisai 4-year PhD programme, QS ION-Cleveland Clinic London Clinical PhD Programme, and the Pat Harris 4-year PhD Fellowship programme. QS ION staff contribute to undergraduate teaching at UCL and for the UCL Medical School, host an Elective programme for final year medical students and participate in the organisation of several CPD courses. The Institute also hosts an intercalated Bachelors of Science (iBSc) degree and will launch a cross-Faculty Bachelors of Science (BSc) in Human Neuroscience in September 2024.

Equality, Diversity & Inclusion

The Institute prides itself on operating in an [all-inclusive environment](#) irrespective of personal, physical, or social characteristics. Teamwork is highly valued, individual strengths are recognised and celebrated, and there is a commitment to advancing the careers of everyone, regardless of sex, gender identity, disability, age, sexual orientation, national origin, race, ethnicity, religion and belief, or social class (this list is not exhaustive).

The Athena SWAN Charter recognises commitment to advancing women's careers in science, technology, engineering, maths, and medicine (STEMM) employment in academia. ION is delighted to have received an Athena Swan Silver Award in October 2015, which was reinstated in July 2020. We have reinforced our commitment to promoting equity and inclusion by signing up to an international declaration, which aims to provide fair and equal opportunities for underrepresented groups in Neurosciences. We stand by our commitment to positive action to improve equality and accessibility in the workplace. We will provide reasonable adjustments to enable people to work and flourish with us. Mentoring is a crucial part of supporting career progression. The Institute offers a range of mentoring schemes tailored to different staff and student groups to promote professional and personal development.

The Institute is proud to uphold both UCL's Dignity at Work and Work-Life Balance policies. As an Institute we commit to fostering a positive cultural climate where all staff and students can thrive and be their authentic selves, and actively support Wellbeing@UCL, the five-year wellbeing strategy for the whole UCL community, supported by our Wellbeing Champions.

Environmental sustainability

The Institute is committed to operating within an environmentally sustainable environment, through the implementation of the UCL Sustainability policy at Departmental level. For more information, please [visit our webpage](#).

About the Department of Neurodegenerative Disease

The Department of Neurodegenerative Disease is one of the foremost international centres for the study of dementia and other neurodegenerative diseases. The

research portfolio encompasses Alzheimer's disease, frontotemporal dementia, Parkinson's disease, and dementia with Lewy bodies.

Highly multidisciplinary and interactive studies span structural and molecular biology, neurogenetics and the full spectrum of clinical research including major cohort studies and therapeutic trials. The research philosophy is to combine basic and clinical translational research; many of the key contributions towards understanding the basic biology of these diseases have come from clinical and neuropathological observations, and efficient translation of basic laboratory research to the clinic is essential to provide benefits for patients at the earliest opportunity.

The UCL Dementia Research Centre (DRC), based in the Department, is a hub for clinical research into various forms of dementia. Our work focuses on identifying and understanding the disease processes that cause dementia, the factors that influence these disease processes, and how best to support people with dementia and their families. In addition to our research, we also provide a cognitive disorders clinic within the National Hospital for Neurology and Neurosurgery.

About the Multimodal Parkinson's Disease Group

The Multimodal Parkinson's Disease group, based within the Dementia Research Centre, is a dynamic and friendly group, working to understand how dementia happens in Parkinson's and related diseases. We use a combination of neuroimaging, PET imaging, psychology and blood and cerebrospinal fluid biomarkers to address this.

Main purpose of the job

You will be part of a research programme dedicated to the detailed clinical, neuropsychological, and MRI characterisation of Lewy Body Dementia (LBD). The programme aims to understand the mechanisms of LBD and provide evidence for future clinical trials in this common and debilitating condition. This will include a collaborative proof of principle study investigating the effects of non-invasive ultrasound stimulation on brain connectivity and cognition in LBD.

You will assist with managing data collected from participants in this project, including image analysis. Your duties will include helping coordinate the study, participant screening and recruitment, neuropsychological testing of people with LBD, data curation, and image analysis focusing on structural, diffusion tensor imaging, resting state functional MRI, and quantitative MRI scans.

The post is available from October 2024 and funded by Wellcome for one year in the first instance.

Duties and responsibilities

- Support the recruitment of participants, including screening prior to attending, and organising study visits.

- Collect cognitive, questionnaire, and imaging data from patients with Lewy body disease.
- Screen patients for MRI scans and keep participant schedule up-to-date and accurate.
- Organise testing materials for patient visits.
- Record and curate study data using databases such as redcap and statistical software such as MATLAB and R.
- Image analysis including pre-processing and quality control of brain imaging data.
- Assist with patient engagement activities.

Teaching, Research and Development

- Provision of teaching on topics related to the post holder's work as requested by the line manager.
- Contributing to the department's multidisciplinary research projects within the strategy.
- Preparing and analysing data for publications for dissemination of research and for presentation at international conferences as well as internal meetings at UCL, and meetings with external collaborators.

General Duties

- Ensuring the highest standard of record keeping, maintaining accurate, complete, and up to date records.
- Ensuring confidentiality is maintained as applicable.
- Attending and contributing to Departmental, Institutional, and other meetings as appropriate.
- Acting at all times in accordance with the highest professional standards and ensuring that these are maintained in the delivery of all aspects of research.
- Ensuring that duties are carried out in a resource efficient way, and actively support UCL's Sustainability Strategy, policies, and objectives.
- Follow and actively promote the UCL [Ways of Working](#).
- Adhering at all times to the policies, rules and regulations of the Department, Institute and UCL.

The above description is not exhaustive, and the post-holder will be required to undertake any other duties as may reasonably be requested within the scope, spirit, and purpose of the post. Job descriptions are reviewed on a regular basis including at the annual appraisal. As duties and responsibilities change, the job description may be amended in consultation with the post-holder.

The post-holder will be expected to actively follow all UCL policies and procedures including Equal Opportunities, maintain an awareness of Fire and Health & Safety Regulations, attend management meetings, and undertake such training and development as may be required for the post.

All staff are required to act professionally, co-operatively, and flexibly in line with the requirements of the post.

Person Specification

Note to job applicant: copy and paste the following criteria (which are assessed on the application form) into your “Statement in support of your application” and describe underneath each criteria how you meet it, giving examples. Desirable criteria will only be scored if there is a tie break for shortlisting.

Essential Criteria	Assessment method (Application form/ Interview / Practical Test)
Qualifications, experience, and knowledge	
Honours degree (minimum 2:1) in Psychology, Neuroscience, or a related discipline	Application form
Knowledge of medical statistics, data processing, and analysis	Application form/Interview
Experience of conducting neuropsychological assessments in adult populations	Application form/Interview
Skills and abilities	
IT proficiency at advanced user level (MS Office suite, Web-based applications, databases and file management)	Application form/Interview
Excellent oral and written communication skills	Application form/Interview
Being resourceful and practical, able to act on own initiative and problem-solve	Application form/Interview
Interested in research and a commitment to supporting high quality research	Application form/Interview
Working methodically, prioritising and managing tasks	Application form/Interview
Building rapport and being comfortable with others across different cultures and backgrounds.	Application form/Interview
A very high level of consideration and care for patients and research subjects	Application form/Interview
Desirable Criteria	
Experience of brain imaging data collection and analysis	Application form/Interview
Experience of working with patients, especially people with Parkinson’s disease or dementias	Application form/Interview
Skills with programming and coding in a relevant language (Python, MATLAB, or R)	Application form/Interview

Apply

To apply for this position visit:

ucl.ac.uk/jobs

Please complete the online application form and use the supporting statement section to outline your interest in joining the Multimodal Parkinson's Disease research group at the Department of Neurodegenerative Disease, and how you meet the essential and desirable criteria for the role. Please also upload a recent CV.

If you have any queries regarding the application process, please contact the Institute HR Team, UCL Queen Square Institute of Neurology, 23 Queen Square, London, WC1N 3BG (email: ion.hradmin@ucl.ac.uk).

For informal enquiries about the role please contact Dr Angeliki Zarkali (email: a.zarkali@ucl.ac.uk).

The post is available from October 2024 and funded by Wellcome for one year in the first instance.

Salary

Starting salary offered between £37,332 - £37,982 per annum, inclusive of London Allowance.

Progression through the salary scale is incremental. Cost of living pay awards are negotiated nationally and are normally effective from 1st August each year.

Probation

Appointments are subject to receipt of satisfactory references and a probationary period of 9 months.

Hours of work

Full time, 36.5 hours per week; times of work are as determined by the line manager or Director.

Hybrid working arrangements

The nature of this role requires you to spend most of your time working on-site (On-site First) and you are expected to spend at least 80% of your working hours on campus.

Annual leave

Annual leave is 27 working days for a full-time member of staff + 6 UCL closure days in addition to 8 Bank Holidays.

Pension

Appointments are superannuable under the [Universities Superannuation Scheme \(USS\)](#) or, subject to eligibility requirements, the National Health Service Pension Scheme (NHSPS).

Other benefits

UCL is a dynamic, global university based in one of the most exciting capital cities in the world. Not only does working at UCL offer the opportunity to work with some of the greatest intellects in the world, it also offers competitive terms, conditions and benefits to its staff. In the 2013 UCL staff survey, 83% of staff would recommend UCL as a good place to work and 86% are proud to work for UCL.

As part of the UCL community you can access free lunch hour lectures, exhibitions and museums and collections. On campus UCL has the Bloomsbury theatre hosting a range of performances and a series of bars, cafes, and other facilities, which UCL staff can use.

In addition to 41 days annual leave (inclusive of public holidays and closure days) and generous pension schemes, UCL provides a number of other staff benefits which are linked from the page below:

✓ <https://www.ucl.ac.uk/human-resources/pay-benefits/staff-benefits>

UCL benefits and policies apply equally, whatever the sexual orientation and/or gender identity of employees. Benefits and policies relating to employees partners, includes both different sex and same sex partners.